

It Is Good to Give Thanks

Spirituality and Simple Pleasures

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The world we live in offers us a broad stock of goods. Life is a generous field for pleasures of many different kinds — spiritual, social and physical pleasures, high and low pleasures, short and sharply focused ones and long and spreading ones. It is not for nothing that we love to live — it is true that we carry an uncontrollable survival instinct, one that operates even when life is painful and unbearable, but beyond that, for the most part we love our lives because there is good in them, joy, abundance; because it is pleasant and enjoyable to live them.

Ordinary religious outlooks relate to the element of pleasure in life in various ways, which can usually be arrayed along a single axis, from indifference and disregard to an openly negative attitude toward it. It is true that within Judaism one cannot find ascetic conceptions in the most extreme sense of the term. Halakha, which binds all the streams of Judaism throughout history into a single movement, does not allow for a total disengagement from life in this world — the commandment of three Sabbath meals, the obligation to marry and be fruitful and multiply, and so on. And yet the basic psychic attitude toward this world, and toward all the abundance it offers, can still remain averse and rejecting, as we find, for example, in the teaching of Rabbeinu Bachya. By contrast, even religious outlooks that do not necessarily sanctify asceticism, and certainly not self-mortification, generally do not relate favorably to the concept of pleasure in itself, let alone regard it as a value.

This is understandable from the very essence of religious consciousness. Religiosity is occupied with the elevation of human life, with directing life toward a higher plane. The basic lexicon of religion, regarding the life of the human soul, is advancement, self-overcoming, self-perfection, sanctification. Life is conceived as having direction and purpose. Only what can be considered, in some broad sense, to serve that purpose and direction can be counted as "of value" from a religious point of view. Against this mode of thought, pleasure is passive and static. It cannot be conceived as a religious value, since it does not signal a passage beyond the mere fact of some destination toward which ordinary life must progress — it is itself the result of ordinary, mundane life of just this sort; it is itself nothing but a passive product of such normal facticity. In another sense, religiosity — like morality — is eccentric [in the literal sense of "off-center"]; both are occupied with directing a person's life, and the aim of his actions, toward a point that lies outside himself, outside his own narrow, self-interested needs and desires — the general good, holiness, the will of God, justice, perfection. Pleasure, by contrast, is by definition egocentric — an act whose purpose is pleasure cannot be considered to carry a sublime

intention. It is hard, then, to speak of "religious value" in enjoying something, or in enjoying life in general.

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And yet — it matters to us to enjoy ourselves.

By the term "matters," I do not mean to grant pleasure a halo of value, meaning or ideal, and I deliberately avoid doing so — pleasure does not belong to the weighty wing of moral and ideological considerations that drive us, and it should not be mixed in with those considerations, with that wing. I am stressing that it matters to us to enjoy ourselves precisely in the sense of light, valueless enjoyment, devoid of ideological importance, so that we do not fall into a false self-conception according to which our soul is composed only of grand, important wishes that fit into an ideological framework of seriousness and gravity. No; we also have marginal, petty, narrowly self-centered, unimportant, trivial sides. This is part of what makes up our humanity. We should not expect an artificial, purified state of mind in which we live only out of ideals, in which we do only important deeds and only for the sake of important goals. And when I speak of these lower sides, I do not mean weaknesses, moral failings, flaws, or anything with a negative sense. I mean the reason it takes us time to choose which kind of tea to drink, the reason it matters to us that the chair we sit on be comfortable, the reason we paint our room's walls in pleasant colors, the reason we cook and eat tasty food and not merely nutritious, healthy food. The reason we go out for a walk, laugh with a friend, read a thriller, listen to a CD on a drive, or buy some little comfort item. None of these trivial actions has an ideological, moral or religious justification — and, in my understanding, none of them ought to. Their "justification," or their reason, is simple — the drive toward what is pleasant and enjoyable is an inseparable part of our human being.

Therefore, the inclination toward pleasure generally occupies no small place in life, even without being linked to the religious inclination in any way. Most of us devote time and energy not only to questions like what is required of me to do, what is important to accomplish, what needs to be done, and so on, but also to questions like what I feel like doing, what will give me satisfaction or a sense of contentment in the near term, what will be more pleasant and nice for me, and so on. This is what normal[1] religious life looks like: there are times when one's psychic focus is spiritual and religious, and there are times when the spiritual effort slackens and we live out of a natural engine of seeking contentment, an instinctive search for pleasures and delights of various kinds. Out of this, the actual place of pleasure — and not only the search for it — expands greatly. There are meaningful stretches of time in our lives in which we simply take joy and pleasure in something — hearing beautiful music, being satisfied by a good, filling meal, going out for some kind of entertainment, meeting good friends whose company is a delight, and so on. These parts of life remain, psychically, disconnected from the holy. They are not part of "religious experience." As noted above, since holiness is active in essence and eccentric in direction, it does not integrate into the state of mind of one who takes delight — or at least of one who delights in the small things of human life, in pleasures in which no embodiment of a

lofty "value" can be found, and toward which our inclination does not stem from greatness of soul or from higher spiritual sides within us, but from the ordinary sides of the mundane.

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As conscious beings, we try to organize the totality of our lives within fixed patterns of thought and categories. We weave the various experiences of life into a narrative, into some overarching story, which is what grants sense to the collection of varied experiences we go through and intend to go through. In simple words, we need every domain and matter in our lives to have meaning, so that we can understand it and its place in our lives. As religious people, the overarching narrative we choose for our lives will, for the most part, be based primarily on the foundations of religious thought.

As a consequence of the fact that mundane pleasure occupies a place in the life of even an ordinary servant of God, deep religious thinkers find themselves needing to clarify this inclination, their task being, primarily, a search for a "justification," or a religious illumination, of this side of life. Indeed, the general direction of the world of faith, and of the spiritual world in general, situates the focus of life in stepping out of the narrow "self" toward some supreme value. The place of simple pleasure in such an inner world will never be central and essential, but always peripheral. Yet even the peripheral regions of life are meant to have a role or a meaning, and religious thought — especially thought grounded in a positive attitude toward the full breadth of life, and a deep demand for authenticity and inner sincerity — seeks the key, the formulation, of what the correct relation to those regions is, and how they fit into the overall direction of religious life.

One could speak of all sorts of ways and arguments by which (mainly modern) religious thinkers validate the mundane and see value in it. I will present, albeit very briefly and in a compressed way, a few argument-lines of this sort that have been voiced in recent Jewish thought:[2]

❖ Rabbi Soloveitchik often argued that engagement with mundane domains, with the development and building of the world, is part of man's mission, expressed in God's blessing-command to the first man: "Be fruitful and multiply, and fill the earth and subdue it, and rule over the fish of the sea and the birds of the sky and every living thing that creeps upon the earth." [3] The argument relates mainly to productive, creative activity — technological, artistic or scientific. [4]

❖ Some have argued that we ought to ground our religious conceptions, first and foremost, in the Bible. [5] In the Bible we find ample room for the aesthetic, the mundane and natural delight. This is the basic spirit that blows through all the books of the Bible. It is true that one can find places where we are warned against being carried away after material abundance, such as the beauty of a woman, [6] or an abundance of food, fine houses, cattle and flocks, silver and gold. [7] But these do not cancel out the basic, encompassing sense that the attitude of the sacred writings toward the mundane, toward abundance and beauty, is not reserved and rejecting but positive — as expressed in the depiction of the patriarchs as wealthy and the

matriarchs as beautiful, in the blessings of material abundance that loving fathers bestow upon their sons, in the request for game to eat, and so on.

❖ Rabbi Kook called for broadening the domains of the religious world so that it would include also the domains of aesthetics and the mundane, which had not been present in ordinary, traditional Judaism. In his teaching we find an explanation for the fact that, in the Judaism of the exile, the place of materiality, of the mundane and of naturalness had shrunk — and that this does not testify to the truth of these things, nor to our vision for the period of the nation's revival in its land. Now that the national revival has begun, one must ascribe great meaning to the domains of the mundane, look upon them in a positive light, and even see in them a divine disclosure, or a part of the world of the holy. The value, importance or supreme role that Rabbi Kook grants to the mundane is interpreted in many different ways throughout his teaching. It is argued that the mundane constitutes a healthy, firm foundation for the holy, such that strengthening the foundation brings about the growth and flourishing of the holiness built upon it; it is argued that expanding material and aesthetic development helps the people of Israel to shine its unique light in the world, thereby influencing all humanity with a dew of holy life; it is argued that within the mundane itself a special divine manifestation is revealed, one that has qualities different from, and in certain senses even higher than, those that appear within the holy; and many other far-reaching and, to a considerable degree, innovative arguments.

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I have not paused to fully establish and elaborate the argument-lines just mentioned, since these conceptions — of granting a legitimate, even respected place to the domains of naturalness and the mundane in life — have already gained fairly solid footing and self-confidence among a broad and serious religious public, whatever the principled, Torah-based reason for this may be. The foundational tension in our lives between the profane and the holy, between the bodily and the spiritual, between the natural and the religious, has been blunted. Thanks to those ideological justifications, we manage to live at peace with ourselves, with all our various sides, not out of a guilty conscience or a begrudging, after-the-fact feeling, but out of genuine self-belief and a sense of walking a rightful path — out of a basic feeling that in all our ways, even those that do not fall under the explicit "way of holiness" but rather under "the way of the world," we are walking the broad path of the service of God. And yet, the point that troubles me is the stage that comes immediately after the establishment and internalization of these religious ideological systems, which grant place and honor to the domains of the mundane — namely, the concrete, everyday, existential stage.

In real, lived existence, the opposition between the concepts of holiness, religiosity and spirituality on the one hand, and the natural, simple experience of the mundane on the other, keeps stirring back to life. It is true that this opposition does not appear in a declared, principled way, in the form of a framework-level clash between "religious" demands and natural, vital forces. The religious framework, the religious ethos, are shaped in light of an ideological conception that regards the mundane and the natural flow of life in a positive light, and so, in

the salient, external, rigid, framework sense, there is no clash, since a person is granted legitimacy to allocate his time and energy to sides of life that carry no moral or religious elevation. If, while engaged in — or dwelling in — the domains of the mundane, some religious-spiritual demand or pang of guilt arises in a person's heart, he will manage to fend it off by way of the logical understandings and successful justifying arguments — something like those brought above — that underlie his spiritual world, and will be able to return to his occupation, or his non-occupation, with peace of mind. And yet, without in any way diminishing the importance of these argument-lines as a foundation for a fully orderly, ideological religious worldview, there remains here a certain existential problem, one that can at times even be quite troubling. This problem is bound up with the process of development and deepening of our religious inclination of soul.

Our religiosity has deepened, has become internalized within us at ever more inward layers, to the point that it would be fair to describe it as standing above life. Owing to our intensive quest for meaning, for a spiritual dimension that would suffuse the ranks of ordinary, one-dimensional, trivial life, it is precisely the religious point of view that grants life its validity and its meaning. Normality, ease, simple flow, appear in our spiritual eyes as gray, as trivial — as the concept of "triviality" increasingly takes on a negative connotation. Religiosity is compelled to spread and extend its presence over every domain of life, in order to grant them not merely legitimacy but also flavor and vitality. The demand — and, more than that, the psychic need — that "all your deeds be for the sake of Heaven"[8] was born out of the deepening and rooting of the point of religiosity in the heart, to the point of its being identified with the very flavor of life — and so, in a certain sense, we no longer want domains of real mundaneness at all, except insofar as they can be connected and related to some religious purpose or activity.

In the end, I feel that there is, within us — within human beings in general — an essential conflict between two inner psychic inclinations. On the one hand, we have an inclination that pushes us toward spiritual tension, an inner yearning to break out beyond the triviality of things, a psychic need to establish a spiritual, elevated, valuable meaning for our raw, given experience of life. We feel that the main meaning of life lies in spiritual intensity, in moral effort, in the project of self-elevation and self-refinement, in the experience of self-transcendence. The trivial, from this point of view, is felt as emptiness and as carrion, and only its elevation into the spiritual breathes vitality and depth into it. For believers, this yearning for spiritual tension translates into religious tension — we wish to grant religious meaning to the mundane sides of our lives. This granting of meaning, carried out through the intention of the heart, does not let life flow spontaneously out of itself, but rather cuts it off from its earthly plane and brings it up to a higher plane, the spiritual-religious plane. But on the other hand, we also have an affection and love for life as it is, in its raw naturalness, and, as part of that love — a love of simple, aesthetic, "mundane" pleasures. Not in everything we do do we want some "meaning" weighing upon us; we do not always crave a "spiritual tension" that would crowd out our enjoyment of the acts of daily life. The natural inclination toward the pleasant and the enjoyable does not

align with the project of elevating and spiritualizing the mundane; and yet both are basic needs embedded deep in our soul.

In this sense, the ideological argument-lines we have presented offer no solution to the problem. The fact that, in principle, I know how to "justify" the place of light, simple mundaneness in my life does not make it truly bound to holiness and to religiosity. I will, indeed, be left with a positive feeling that I am "okay," but this feeling offers no answer at all to the basic psychic yearning for spiritual tension. The trivial remains trivial. Even when I have the tools to think about it positively and to believe that it has value, this does not change its actual, existential character, which is opaque and raw and indifferent to the plane of height and value. It is true that this yearning for spiritual tension does not rage within us with the same intensity at all times, and it is quite plausible that we will live long stretches of time in naturalness and flow without feeling the lack of some higher, meaningful dimension in our conduct; but there will still be times, and there will be general thoughts and feelings, in which this conflict surfaces. Hence, the question that troubles me is not how to justify the mundane from a religious point of view — a question whose answers lie on the theological and ideological plane — but rather an existential question: how can one connect, in a truly genuine way, the domains of mundane life and pleasure to religiosity.

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In my search for an answer to this question, I have passed (so far) through three main stations. Before proposing the third station, in whose praise I wish to speak in this essay, I will present the two other conceptions that set my mind at ease for a significant period of time, and the reasons for which I abandoned these conceptions — or, more precisely, the reasons for which I found it difficult to see in these conceptions, even though there is a measure of truth in them, a sufficient solution to the problem. This is in order to clarify the relative advantage of the third answer proposed below, and what difficulties it comes to address.

The worldview that first captured my heart, allowing me to live the domains of the mundane in a way that carried a genuine, existential connection to the holy, is the conception that can be briefly expressed in the maxim "let all your deeds be for the sake of Heaven." As Maimonides interprets and formulates it:

It is fitting for a person to enslave all the powers of his soul to the intellect, as we have set forth in the preceding chapter, and to set before his eyes one single end, namely: the apprehension of God, may He be glorified and exalted [...] and to make all his actions, his movements and his rest, and all his words, lead toward this end [...]

For example: that he should intend, in his eating, his drinking, his intercourse, his sleep, his waking, and his motion and rest — the health of his body alone; and the purpose of the health of his body is that the soul should find its instruments healthy and whole, so as to grasp the sciences and acquire the moral and rational virtues,

until he attains that final end. And by this reasoning he will not, at that point, intend pleasure alone, so as to choose from food and drink only the most pleasant, and likewise in his other conduct, but will intend what is beneficial — and if it happens to be pleasant, so be it, and if it happens to be repugnant, so be it. Or he will intend the pleasant in accordance with medical reasoning — as when his appetite for food has weakened, he will arouse it with pleasant, well-seasoned foods of desire. And likewise, if a black bile [melancholy] has been aroused in him, he will remove it by listening to songs and kinds of music, and by strolling in gardens and fine buildings, and by sitting among beautiful forms, and other such things that expand the soul and remove from it the worry of black bile. And in all this his intention shall be that his body be healthy, and the purpose of his body's health is that he may know. Likewise, when he moves about and occupies himself with acquiring wealth, his purpose in gathering it shall be that he may use it for the virtues, and that he may find in it the means to sustain his body and the continuation of his existence, until he attains and knows of God whatever it is possible to know.

Eight Chapters [Maimonides' introduction to Pirkei Avot], ch. 5

In my initial encounter with these words, I was filled with joy and enthusiasm. At last, the domains of the mundane would be redeemed from the straits of their own triviality and rise up to become possessed of value and meaning, if only I directed toward them the proper purposive intention, if only I managed to experience them out of religious aspiration, out of the love of God.

I have already related to this conception, and to the problem it contains — whether between the lines or more directly — in the preceding sections. In brief, I will sum up that the infinite demandingness this way of life imposes leads to one of two undesirable results (or to both): 1. Suffocation — the spiritual strain involved in trying to direct every small and large action in light of a religious purpose grows and grows, until there arises a sense that the task is impossible, does not fit human nature, and does not respect the natural sides of the soul that seek their place. 2. Fakery — the person continues to shape his everyday behavior in exactly the same way it would have been had he not decided that "all his deeds shall be for the sake of Heaven," while his inner world is occupied with a tasteless, apologetic self-justification before himself, according to which his intention in banal acts is, in fact, sublime, and his purpose in pleasurable acts is, in fact, entirely spiritual.

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My reservations about this instrumentalist-teleological mode of justifying the domains of the mundane led me toward directions of thought that see in them an essential value in their own right. I received and learned these directions mainly under the influence of the teaching of Rav Kook. In almost every line and paragraph of his writings, one can sense his respect for every single thing and matter created under the heavens — "Do not scorn any person, and do not dismiss anything, for there is no person who does not have his hour, and nothing that does not

have its place." [9] My sense was that the challenge of giving each thing its proper due is what stirs his spirit and sets the wheels of his thought in motion. The tenor of his words is always positive; he forever seeks the good side, the spark of holiness, the point of truth, in every tendency and movement, in every force and phenomenon, in every inclination and manifestation of life. The deeper I went into his spiritual teaching, the clearer it became to me that the foundation of it all, the root of the empathetic spirit, the good eye, the optimistic tone, are anchored in a radical, revolutionary theological conception, according to which everything — is divinity. [10] Everything that exists in the world is a divine manifestation, and by virtue of this it carries within it an inner kernel of good, an inner divine point, even if hidden and covered by thick coverings. When this conception is applied to the mundane domains of our lives — those that carry great or small emotional significance for us but which we cannot categorize, in our own minds, as possessing genuine value of truth and of goodness — the heart fills with a light of joy and hope, like a pillar of fire that suddenly descends and illuminates the darkness. As Rav Kook describes it:

One must show the way of how to enter the parlor — through the gate. The gate is the divinity revealed in the world, in the world in all its beauty and glory, in every spirit and soul, in every living and creeping thing, in every plant and flower, in every nation and kingdom, in the sea and its waves, in the vault of the sky and the splendor of the luminaries, in the talents of every conversation, in the ideas of every author, in the imaginings of every poet and the reasonings of every thinker, in the feeling of every one who feels and in the storm of valor of every hero. The supreme divinity, which we yearn to reach, to be absorbed within, to be gathered into its light, and which we cannot attain in that full measure that would satisfy our desire — descends, of itself, for our sake, into the world and within it, and we find it and delight in its love, finding rest and peace in its calm.

Orot, Zera'onim, Tzimaon le-El Chai, p. 119

The idea that all of existence is nothing but a matter of divinity, and that there is nothing at all apart from God, delights the heart greatly. And the spiritual delight that this idea produces is itself the proof of the truth expressed through it.

Shemonah Kevatzim, I, 55

Following this encounter with Rav Kook's immanentist theology, a way of resolving the question of the mundane's disconnection from spirituality and from holiness suggested itself. Every life experience can, in fact, be a religious experience, if only we remember that it truly is one; the gap between the trivial and the spiritual, the elevation of the mundane and the neutral to the rank of holiness, lies in a subtle but powerful shift of consciousness, one that attributes the source of all things to God. In the context of pleasures and delights, this experience is even easier, more fluid, almost natural. Since all existing things, all the abundance that exists in the world, are all an embodiment and a disclosure of the light of God, delighting in a fine wine, or taking pleasure in a good song, is, in fact, delighting in the goodness of God. Becoming aware of

this — that is, contemplating and focusing on it — genuinely transforms the character of the delighted experience from an opaque, chemical-neural process into a meaning-bearing act, and refines the pleasure into a deep experience of devotion (deveikut). This does not cut us off from the plain, trivial plane in a way that makes us feel alienated from some naturalness that exists within us, as we may have felt in the previous conception, but rather allows us to live the simple experience at its natural, primary level and to taste within it, in its own right, the delicacies of the Garden of Eden.[11]

My heart was filled with the hope that, through the panentheistic theological conception — the one that believes in an immanent divinity revealed in every mark, point and trickle of reality — the obstacles that disconnect the trivial-mundane from the holy had been removed. It is true that one should somewhat narrow the existential implications of this conception — since it would be impossible, and above all unfitting, to experience the greatness of holiness and of cleaving to the divine in every gray moment and every banal action — I thought that, at the very least, we could focus on the plane of natural pleasures. Every matter in which a person encounters an illuminating feeling, a pleasant experience, a positive sensation, would be perceived and experienced as a disclosure of divinity. Every delight is a delight in God; every pleasure is an experience of devotion. What separates us is only the partition of consciousness, the screen of imagination that prevents us from seeing this real truth. The more we contemplate, and the more we come to know and internalize the secret that "the whole earth is full of His glory," the more all our pleasures will become sanctified.[12]

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Except that this last existential "solution," too, harbors a trap that renders it, in this context, worthless, and empties it of its ability to solve the problem. Just as panentheistic theology must always preserve the duality within the divine concept — the fact that He fills all worlds and yet, at the same time, surrounds and encompasses them; that He is both immanent, containing all of being within Him, and also a transcendent, sublime, inconceivable infinity — so too, and correspondingly, must the state of a person's consciousness in relation to the divine concept be preserved. A routine of life in which a person becomes accustomed to linking every earthly state of being to his concept of divinity, without there being, alongside this, a feeding of transcendent contents and images into that concept; an everyday experience saturated with "pantheistic" contemplation and experience, without any counterweight of the experience of "holiness" — these lead to a secularization and a profanation of the divine concept. The name "divinity" becomes bound up with the earth and its fullness, with the entire abundance of the various things in existence, and no longer carries within it any separation or distinction, high and low, good and evil. Such a concept is, in fact, a concept that is not only mundane, but even hollow — one more word to describe "the All," "being," "the world," carrying no added value beyond the simple, primary depictions of these.[13]

It is true that, above, we proposed narrowing this contemplation, and not applying it to literally every single thing, but only to the good — that is, to the pleasant and enjoyable abundance we

encounter in the world. But even so, we remain caught in a similar trap. When a person grows accustomed to attributing all his positive experiences, without any distinction among moral or spiritual categories of judgment, to a place within the soul that he calls "devotion" (deveikut), then that place no longer has the power to elevate, to raise up, to sanctify; it has no "religious" effect on the soul at all, and loses the justification for being called by a divine name, by a name that purports to ascribe value to it, or by any special name at all. It would be better to keep using the term "pleasure" — this verbal sophistication ceases to carry any meaning. It no longer expresses a shift in awareness; it is no longer a filling, exhilarating religious illumination; it is no longer a panentheistic religious experience.

From the other direction, if your concept of the divine is indeed powerful, full of sublimity, separateness and holiness, and it is not drawn down and submerged into the smallness of the limited world but, on the contrary, draws that world up toward its own heavenly summit — then the panentheistic existential experience may be caught in the opposite trap. The attempt to apply the greatness and sublimity of the divine to a small, material, trivial mundane experience runs into dissonance, into disharmony. This applies especially to the demanding attempt to live within such a consciousness over an extended period of time. At some stage, the small pleasure, upon which such high, deep, holy and lofty worlds of content have been loaded, fails to bear this weight; it fails both to carry these heavy meanings upon it and to continue being a simple, natural, light experience. As already noted above in different terms, the mundane is, in its essence, a matter of lightness of being, something that does not carry a heavy charge of value and importance. Natural life is constantly full of such experiences, ones we take joy in and love precisely because of their natural flow, their simplicity and their lightness. Loading devotion — deep, serious, sanctity-laden devotion — onto every single moment suffocates the normal vitality that breathes through life, and at some stage disconnects us from the simplicity of life's pleasures, a simplicity that constitutes part of their very essence. This disconnection extinguishes something in us, since our soul needs this simple, natural pleasure like air to breathe, as though it were the very oxygen of the love of life.

In short, one could put it this way: except for the most foundational of saints, the most supremely holy, it is impossible to turn everything into the holy and keep it holy. Either everything gradually empties out, emptying along with it the content of holiness, or the mundane demands its freedom, until holiness reverts to being reserved, set apart and special, leaving most of life outside its domain.

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It is clear, then, that one should not translate every feeling of contentment and satisfaction, every joy and pleasure in some particular thing, into a delighting in God, and one should not make an effort to contemplate and see the divine manifestation in every single thing at all times. One should reserve this supreme contemplation — which is true, deep and just in its own right — for rare moments, for especially powerful sensations, or for a most significant experience.

How, then, can we nonetheless elevate our pleasures? How can we raise them up and include them within our religious world?

It seems to me that the optimal existential-religious solution to this problem lies in a religious consciousness of gratitude. Our pleasures — even the most banal, material and simple of them — will receive their spiritual refinement by being attributed not to the essence of God, but to the kindness (*chesed*) of God. Through the remembrance that God is the Creator of the world in the fullness of its abundance and goodness, that He desires our joys and our delights, and that He it is who created, for me, this very thing in which I find joy, and this very experience of sweet delight and pleasant satisfaction — my pleasure will be freed of its opaqueness and will rise up to become a religious experience as well. "Who lacked nothing in His world, and created in it goodly creatures and goodly trees, for human beings to delight in."

As in other cases, I feel that we search too far when there is an answer that lies close by. We seek, for our spiritual and religious longings, a response in sophisticated religious models, in elaborate and polished theological structures, and in doing so we push the simple foundations of our religious world away from the center of our discourse and contemplation. Often I find that we miss out, by failing to draw out from what already lies openly in our primary, basic sources the full abyssal depth and rich vitality contained within them, and instead try to run ahead. Whoever examines the Bible, and likewise the words of our sages and halakha, finds gratitude to God to be an essential and very basic part of the religious world, both the communal-faith dimension and the personal-religious one — occupying a more central place than it does in our religious discourse today. Gratitude is built into biblical religiosity, and it seems to fill a dominant role within it. It functions as a foundation of psalms of praise and thanksgiving and of the offering of sacrifices, as a basis for the Ten Commandments,[14] for accepting the yoke of the Kingdom of Heaven and for the commandment to love God,[15] as the essence of festivals and of many commandments.[16] It is a central axis of prayer and a foundation for the entire world of blessings.[17] It is present, openly or by implication, in many of the words of the great figures of the nation, whose lips were forever full of the name of Heaven.[18] In short, gratitude is a cornerstone in the existential experience of the believer, as this is reflected in the sacred writings.

Gratitude is a refining feeling. Gratitude does not impose upon experiences of joy and pleasure some foreign content that crowds out their expansion and outpouring, and it does not load upon them a paralyzing weight. Gratitude, when experienced as justified and as not injuring the basic ego, is a natural and fruitful continuation of joy itself. This does, indeed, require an effort of concentration and intention, since it is easy to experience all the good that exists as self-evident, as a given, as something that simply stands on its own, by right and not by grace[19]; but the remembrance that the world was created by divine will, and that everything is given to us by the grace of God, does not stand in frontal contradiction to this ordinary, primary experience, does not challenge it and does not clash with it. It only opens it up, freeing it from its trivial "just-so-ness," granting it a possible horizon of faith and love. This remembrance raises the reception of abundance from the level of natural pleasure to a devotional experience —

every spark of joy and delight is interpreted as an illumination of the Holy One's countenance toward me, and thereby genuinely becomes such.

Positive feelings are united at their root, and so gratitude brings the joy of receiving a good thing into love for the giver, and the two become interwoven and inflame one another. Gratitude opens up egocentric delight into a dialogical experience, and thereby elevates it, refines it and gives it flavor. I am glad not only because I have received satisfaction and delight from some particular thing, but because there is someone who turns toward me and truly and sincerely wants my good and rejoices in my pleasure; there is someone who loves me and grants his own meaning to my joy. My joy at the other's love for me, expressed through a gift, mingles with the simple joy of receiving the gift; the material, self-interested delight becomes a gesture, an encounter, a coming-together.

Religious gratitude, directed at the Creator of the world and His goodness, the source of blessing and abundance, leaves the concept of divinity in its sublimity and its holiness; it turns, like the rest of our religious experiences, toward that same ordinary, transcendent, monotheistic God, whose essence remains hidden and sublime beyond us and at whose seeking of us, and turning toward us, we never cease to marvel. And yet it penetrates to the depth of every sense of goodness and of every pleasure, great or small, important or trivial. On the one hand it unites and blends harmoniously with them, and on the other hand it refines and elevates them by linking them to divine abundance and to a religious remembrance. Spirituality, here, involves no evasion whatsoever of delight; on the contrary, the delight itself is what spurs the heart to a humble and enthusiastic stance before God, is what fans the flame of divine love, the wish to praise and extol the Creator of the world, and, along with it, the deep sense of duty toward Him and the wish to give Him pleasure.

This is not an attempt to attach, to every trifle, the full weight of the obligation to acknowledge the goodness of the One who created us and sustains us at every moment; the feeling of gratitude is calibrated to match the measure of goodness and joy we feel in that particular moment, from that particular pleasure. For a great kindness we have received, we will be filled with great gratitude, and for a small pleasure — small gratitude. The experience of gratitude rests on the foundation of sincerity, and one should not artificially manufacture a feeling of gratitude where there is no genuine sense that something good has happened to us, or that something is pleasant to us, merely because "it is proper to say thanks." And yet, just as with a gift received from someone who loves us, the very feeling of gratitude toward the one who gave us the thing, when it is done with intention and attentiveness, can elevate the value of the enjoyable good and increase its goodness and its sweetness in our eyes.

* * *

The complete redemption for which our eyes wait and our hearts yearn is described with a striking presence of the feeling of gratitude. Salvation, which expresses the most supreme state to which humanity, and the world in general, will arrive, is painted in the colors of delight and of

abundance, resting, as its basis, on the living, delighted recognition that all these come from the goodness of God, blessed be He —

And it shall be said on that day: Behold, this is our God; we have waited for Him, and He will save us. This is the LORD; we have waited for Him. Let us be glad and rejoice in His salvation.

Isaiah 25:9

And you shall draw water with joy from the wellsprings of salvation. And you shall say on that day: Give thanks to the LORD, call upon His name, make known His deeds among the peoples.

Ibid. 12:3-4

In the future, all sacrifices will be nullified, but the thanksgiving offering will never be nullified; all confessions [of praise] will be nullified, but thanksgiving will never be nullified. As it is written (Jer. 33:11): "The voice of joy and the voice of gladness, the voice of the bridegroom and the voice of the bride, the voice of those who say, Give thanks to the LORD of Hosts, for the LORD is good, for His kindness is everlasting — as they bring thanksgiving offerings to the house of the LORD."

Vayikra Rabbah [Vilna], Parashat Emor 27:12

Notes

1. By the term "normal," I do not mean to render a value judgment, but rather to present a picture of the state of most religious people, excluding exceptional, singular saints who indeed devote all the time and energy at their disposal to the domain of the holy.

2. To be precise, let me clarify here a certain distinction that risks being blurred in the course of the discussion. From this point on I am referring, in parallel, to two concepts that are not identical to one another — the mundane, and pleasure (or "mundane pleasures"). The focus of the essay — as clearly presented in its opening and its closing — is the subject of pleasures; but this subject belongs to the broader domain of the mundane, such that pleasure is a sub-domain of the mundane. The argument-lines I will set out below grant justification to the mundane, but from within this one can perhaps also derive — and some have tried to derive — justification for the more focused plane of mundane pleasures. Sometimes this attempted derivation succeeds easily, and sometimes it is more difficult. This is the case regarding the teleological conception brought below in the name of Maimonides. The solution to the general question of the mundane contains, at least on its face, a solution to the question of pleasure as well, even though the domain of pleasure has features that set it apart, since it is contained within the larger category of the mundane.

3. Gen. 1:28.

4. See, for example, Divrei Hagut ve-Ha'arakha, p. 12; Yemei Zikaron, p. 32; and Uvikashtem mi-Sham, in: Ish ha-Halakha — Galuy ve-Nistar, p. 155.

5. See Rabbi Yuval Sherlo, "Ha'im ha-Tanakh Haya" [Did the Bible Exist], Megadim 33, pp. 75–121.

6. Mainly in the book of Proverbs. See, for example, Prov. 11:22.

7. Deut. 8:12–14.

8. See below, in the next section.

9. Avot 4:3.

10. The accepted way of briefly characterizing and defining this theological system, whose name is panentheism, is with the words "everything is within divinity." I have slightly altered the formulation in order to stress a somewhat different point, but in overall meaning it is the same picture.

11. It goes without saying that this contemplation, the intending of oneself toward it, and certainly the sustaining of it, are not easy tasks to carry out. There is a human effort involved here, a struggle of consciousness, a challenge that requires investment and energy. In a certain sense, the effort this solution demands is an essential part of any solution whatsoever, since without an investment of energy, a person would not be answering his need for "spiritual tension," his need for an existential state of striving toward growth, elevation and self-perfection. Not only do we not fear effort — we seek it out and desire it. A "magic solution," one that does not involve the demanding psychic ferment, could never solve the problem, since a state involving no inner confrontation at all, in which a person lives out of a spontaneous flow with his own nature, stands in frontal opposition to spirituality of any kind.

In what way, then, is this path better than the first path I rejected above?

It seems there is a large and significant difference. In the panentheistic conception, things have an inner value in their own right, whether or not I remember and recognize that value at the moment I encounter the thing. The task is to remember as much as possible, to etch into

consciousness the reflection of the divine within every single thing — but whether or not I remembered, no illegitimate or worthless acts have been performed. There is an aspiration to constant devotion, and it presses me to exert myself and concentrate as much as I can, but it does not pull out from under me the stable ground of basic ease in my life during the times when I do not meet this task. By contrast, in the teleological conception, if I did not remember that my intention in this act was the important goal of fulfilling the commandments or knowing God, then apparently that really was not my intention, and I did it "for no reason," out of natural willpower or the pursuit of pleasure. In that case, not only did I fail to rise — I actually descended, deviating from the proper way of life. In the panentheistic conception, I do not clothe the natural inclination in a value external to it, but rather go deeper into its own inner root; the intention toward devotion does not confront the natural layer but rather exposes its true, original nature. In the teleological conception, by contrast, the entire meaning of the natural act of pleasure is located in its incidental outcome, and the act itself, in its own right, is granted no place.

12. I have presented this second path of solution without a representative spokesman. Indeed, I am not convinced that anyone actually argues that this is how one ought to live in practice. It is true that I mentioned and quoted Rav Kook, who without doubt lays the theological and principled groundwork for the direction I have proposed, but I am cautious about saying that he in fact called for experiencing all of reality, or at least all of reality's pleasant and beautiful sides, as a divine revelation and as devotion. The expressions closest to such a position that I found are in the words of Rabbi Chaim Vidal, in his essay "Be-Khol Derakhekha Da'ehu" ["In All Your Ways, Know Him"], in which he interprets Rav Kook's explanation of this verse in Musar Avikha, p. 25. From studying the essay, it was not entirely clear to me whether this is indeed the same position, or whether, despite the apparent closeness, his intention differs somewhat. I will quote here part of the essay, which expresses, in a clear and poetic style, the existential direction mentioned, and whoever wishes to go deeper and be more precise should consult it there at length:

"And so with everything one does" — this is the interpretation of the additional scope of "in all your ways," of every "thing in the world" not included in "Torah," "worship" and "acts of loving-kindness," as above. In these too we shall seek, and find, and know God, when we strive with all our intellect and powers to do them as they are in their fullest perfection, in all their aspects. That is, when we do them with the utmost respect and seriousness, with joy and gladness of heart (and a touch of humor will not hurt), with dedication and concentration, and with the greatest possible investment in planning and execution. Not "for the sake of a commandment," and not "for the sake of Heaven," and not even in order "to do the will of God." Not in the kabbalistic manner of "service that fulfills a supernal need," and not in the Hasidic manner of "service through corporeality," but li-shmah — for the sake of the thing itself, for its own inherent value, and not merely as a means.

And here, toward the end, the Rav illuminates the foundational, faith-based basis of this guidance of his: everything the Holy One created in His world, He created entirely for His glory — that is, for the sake of the disclosure of the divine light-of-value. Everything — literally, in the plainest sense — the emanated and the created, the formed and the made, the heavens and the earth and all their host, the whole of

creation — all of it is a disclosure of the glory of God. The glory of God fills creation, dwells and is revealed within it, in all its layers and parts, in every mighty force of nature, spiritual and physical, and in its every drop and droplet, in the cedar of Lebanon and in the hyssop growing on the wall. In every path a person walks, even when he steps outside the "official" domain of the holy, he walks among landscapes of divine glory, colored in countless hues, playing in countless sounds, speaking in countless languages. The most wonderful thing that can happen to us [...] is that even as we walk these paths (in which we spend most of our lives) we should not, all at once, slip into a mundane, practically purposive state of mind, and should not cease seeking and knowing God even within them. In these too we shall walk with sensitivity and attentiveness, thirsting for intimate encounters and deep touches, delightful and purifying, joyous and beneficial ones. To the very extent that a person meets each thing with all his heart, soul and might, with his whole personality and humanity, out of an opening of himself toward it as it truly is, and a listening and speaking to it in its own particular language, the encounter is freed from the dullness of routine and the alienation of the mundane, as well as from the compulsiveness and inauthenticity that can attach to the holy. Every act thereby becomes knowledge of God [...]

For example: eating — precisely as a clearly mundane activity, not in the context of a religious festive meal, and not only in the context of the psycho-physical health benefit we derive from it — when done in the right and best way, that is, at the right time and place, in the right quantity and quality, with moderation and a cheerful countenance, with enjoyment and simple delight in the pleasant taste, alone or in company, and so forth — is, in fact, knowledge of God. Eating, as a real occurrence of living connection to life — that is, to the divine presence (Shekhinah), as it is truly found and present, revealed and realized in food and in eating, rather than as it lies hidden within it — is knowledge of God. [...] And likewise, the knowledge of God present in a walk is the very fulfillment of it as a walk — the preparation and the execution, walking in the blazing sun and resting in the shade of a tree, breathing in the scents, the sights, the sounds, the delight and enchantment at the view, the pleasure of bread and cool water. And so, too, the knowledge of God present in listening to music, in reading a book, in conversation with friends, in playing with a child, and so on.

Rabbi Chaim Vidal, "Be-Khol Derakhekha Da'ehu — Beyond Religiosity and Secularity," Asif 1, pp. 366–368.

13. It is true that, in our daily lives, we do have "holiness-type" religious experiences that introduce transcendent content into the divine concept — such as prayers, the observance of commandments, moral aspirations. But quantitatively, the balance cannot be sustained, since the consciousness of "everything is within divinity" swallows up the meaning of these within the pantheistic-devotional medley that spreads over the full breadth of life.

14. "I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of bondage" (Ex. 20:2).

15. "You shall fear the LORD your God; Him shall you serve, and to Him shall you cleave, and by His name shall you swear. He is your praise, and He is your God, who has done for you these great and awesome things which your eyes have seen. Your fathers went down to Egypt with seventy persons, and now the LORD your God has made you as the stars of heaven for multitude. And you shall love the LORD your God, and keep His charge, and His statutes, and His judgments, and His commandments, always" (Deut. 10:20–11:1). See also the whole of Parashat Eikev.

16. Passover, Sukkot, the second tithe, first fruits, and more.

17. It is not clear whether the word *barukh* denotes praise or thanks, to the extent that a distinction can be drawn between them at all. In the blessings over enjoyment, over time, and over the commandments, there is certainly a note of thanks.

18. Such as Jacob, Joseph, Daniel.

19. And as noted above (note 11), the fact that some solution requires "effort" is, in fact, evidence in favor of its capacity to solve the problem, since without effort — when the experience is close to being spontaneous and "normal" — there is no spiritual tension and no sense of meaning.